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SUNDAY, SEPTEMBER 21, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Tax hikes loom for South, West sides

Increased investment in areas has led to rising property assessments, likely resulting in higher bills for homeowners

By A.D. Quig and Alex Nitkin

This story is a collaboration between the Illinois Answers Project and the Chicago Tribune.

Leodus Thomas Jr. sees a brighter future for Chicago's West Side. It's why, after buying his house in Austin nine years ago, he decided to become a developer. But in the last several years, a new threat has emerged. "We find (distressed properties) and get them back on the tax roll — but lately we've been punished for that — big-time," Thomas said.

Rising investment in the area has triggered rising property assessments, which in turn will likely result in higher property tax bills. Thomas bought his red brick, two-story home in 2016 for \$135,000. Two years ago, the Cook County assessor's office pegged its value for tax purposes at about \$163,000. Last year, he got a new valuation: \$260,000. That will translate to about a \$700 hike on his annual tax bill compared to last year, according to an analysis by Illinois Answers Project and the Chicago Tribune.

It makes sense for taxes to increase gradually to meet the market, Thomas said. But the looming shock this year to his home and other investment properties will hurt his ability to invest more in future developments. "Coming from the top, they want affordable housing in the city," Thomas said. "But that's almost impossible with how we're being taxed." Thomas saw a nearly 60% increase in his assessment, but it could have been a lot worse, given

Turn to Taxes, Page 14



Residential properties throughout the South and West sides, like these shown on Thursday in West Garfield Park, had their property assessments double or even triple last year. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



‘AN ICON OF ILLINOIS’

Former Gov. Jim Edgar remembered for his compassion, integrity and honesty

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — The late former Gov. Jim Edgar was memorialized Saturday as a man whose compassion, integrity, and honesty showed he put people above politics and led Illinois as a model of what competent governance used to be — and should be — especially during today's sharply partisan and divided times. Edgar, a Republican who served two terms as the state's 38th governor from 1991 to 1999 and a decade before that as secretary of state, died Sept. 14, after having an adverse reaction to treatment for the pancreatic cancer he was diagnosed with in January. He was 79. A bipartisan audience of more than 300 family, friends, former staff and agency



Former Gov. Jim Edgar lectures at the University of Illinois in 1999. **PHIL VELASQUEZ/TRIBUNE**

directors, as well as past and current public officials, gathered Saturday at Central Baptist Church in the state's capital to celebrate Edgar's life, to remember his service to Illinois and to grieve his passing. Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker, who consulted Edgar for advice, said the former governor's "values and judgment and service have been a model to follow" and called the former governor "an icon of Illinois." "Jim Edgar believed deeply in our individual and our collective responsibility to one another — that regardless of where we live, what we look like or who we voted for, our foremost obligation is to serve one another. That is how he governed," Pritzker said.

Turn to Edgar, Page 10

Street vendors quietly disappear

A culture at risk in city as corners go empty during ICE surge

By Laura Rodríguez Presa and Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

A gentle breeze carried the scent of sweet fruit and earthy vegetables from Rodolfo Espinoza's produce stand on an early Tuesday morning on the Southwest Side of Chicago. Espinoza and his wife carefully arranged their produce under a blue tarp: bananas nestled among the tomatoes, serrano peppers between the strawberries, avocados stacked next to mangos. The tarp serves as a makeshift shelter that shields their products from the hot sun in the summer and biting wind during winter. "¡Buenos días, pásele, pásele!" Espinoza cheerfully called out to passersby, inviting them to browse his offerings. "Good morning, come in, come in." A señora, wrapped in a rebozo and wearing an apron, stopped to buy peppers. Most of Espinoza's customers, he said, are familiar faces from the neighborhood. After his first sale of the day, Espinoza made the sign of the cross. Lately, sales have been slow. "People don't really go out anymore. They're scared of ICE. We're scared too, but we have no other choice," Espinoza said. "With God's grace, nothing will happen to us." In the three weeks since President Donald Trump's Department of Homeland Security announced the start of "Operation Midway Blitz," its latest immigration enforcement surge in the Chicago region, street vendors and their

Turn to Vendors, Page 2

IN CHICAGOLAND: Results of President Donald Trump's ICE "blitz" in Chicago area remain unclear more than two weeks in. **Page 3**

Russia launches large-scale-attack

Ukrainian officials on Saturday said Russia targeted regions across Ukraine with missiles and drones, killing at least three people and injuring dozens more. **Nation & World**

Two defenseless teams

The Bears play host to the Cowboys at Soldier Field on Sunday in a matchup between teams with defensive units that have gotten off to inauspicious starts. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 78 Low 65

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 22

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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